



Student Setup Guide — do this BEFORE Session 1

You'll work on **two devices at once**:

-  a **laptop**, where you *write* the code, and
-  a **phone**, where the app *runs* (through the free **Expo Go** app).

They talk to each other over **Wi-Fi**. Set everything up below — it takes ~15–20 minutes once. If you get stuck, jump to [Troubleshooting](#) or ask the instructor.

✓ **Goal of this guide:** see the words *"Open up App.js to start working on your app!"* on your phone.

Part A — Laptop setup

1. Install Node.js (this gives you the tools we run)

1. Go to <https://nodejs.org>.
2. Download the **LTS** version (the big green button on the left).
3. Run the installer — keep clicking **Next / Continue** with the default options.
4. **Verify it worked.** Open a terminal:
 - **Windows:** press **Win**, type **PowerShell**, open it.
 - **macOS:** press **Cmd+Space**, type **Terminal**, open it.
 - **Linux:** open your **Terminal** app.

Type these two commands (press Enter after each):

```
node --version
npm --version
```

You should see version numbers like `v22.x.x` and `10.x.x`. **Numbers = success.** ✅ (If you instead see *"command not found"*, close the terminal, reopen it, and try again. Still failing? Reinstall Node and restart your laptop.)

2. Install a code editor

Download **Visual Studio Code**: <https://code.visualstudio.com>. Install with defaults. This is where you'll write your app.

💡 Optional but nice: inside VS Code, open the Extensions panel (the four-squares icon) and install **"React Native Tools"** and **"Prettier"**.

Part B — Phone setup

3. Install Expo Go

Install the **Expo Go** app:

- **Android:** Google Play → "Expo Go"
- **iPhone:** App Store → "Expo Go"

Open it once. You can skip / dismiss the sign-in — an account is **not** required for this workshop.

Part C — Run the workshop app

You have two options. **Option 1** (clone the repo) is what we'll use in class.

Option 1 — Clone the workshop repository

In your terminal:

```
# Download the code
git clone https://github.com/melvinmmelo/react-native-expo-workshop.git

# Go into it
cd react-native-expo-workshop

# Switch to Session 1's app
git checkout session-1

# Install the app's building blocks (takes a minute the first time)
npm install

# Start it!
npx expo start
```

Don't have **git**? Install it from <https://git-scm.com/downloads>, or just download the repo as a ZIP from GitHub (green **Code** button → **Download ZIP**), unzip it, and **cd** into the folder.

Option 2 — Create a brand-new app from scratch

```
npx create-expo-app@latest my-first-app --template blank
cd my-first-app
npx expo start
```

Scan the QR code

When **npx expo start** runs, a **QR code** appears in your terminal. Make sure your **phone and laptop are on the same Wi-Fi**, then:

- **Android:** open **Expo Go** → **"Scan QR code"** → point at the terminal.
- **iPhone:** open the built-in **Camera** app → point at the QR → tap the yellow **"Open in Expo Go"** banner.

The app loads on your phone in a few seconds. 🎉

 **Hot reload:** keep the app open. Change a word in **App.js**, save the file, and watch your phone update instantly. This is the magic loop we'll use all workshop.

Troubleshooting

Problem	Fix
QR scan does nothing / app won't connect	Phone and laptop must be on the same Wi-Fi . Disable VPNs.
Campus / public Wi-Fi blocks the connection	Run <code>npx expo start --tunnel</code> (slower, but works across networks). First run may install one extra package — say yes.
<code>'node' is not recognized / command not found: node</code>	Node isn't installed or the terminal was open before installing. Reinstall Node, then restart the terminal (or the laptop).
<code>'npx' is not recognized</code>	Same as above — npx ships with Node. Reinstall Node LTS.
Stuck on a white screen or weird error on the phone	In the terminal press <code>r</code> to reload. Still stuck? Press <code>Ctrl+C</code> , then run <code>npx expo start -c</code> (clears the cache).
<code>npm install</code> fails	Check your internet, then delete the <code>node_modules</code> folder and run <code>npm install</code> again.
"Expo Go keeps crashing"	Update Expo Go from the app store; this workshop targets Expo SDK 56 .
Totally blocked in class	Use the web fallback: open https://snack.expo.dev in your browser and code there — no install needed.

Pre-Session-1 checklist

- ☐ `node --version` shows a number
- ☐ `npm --version` shows a number
- ☐ VS Code is installed
- ☐ **Expo Go** is installed on my phone
- ☐ My phone and laptop are on the **same Wi-Fi**
- ☐ I ran an app and saw it on my phone (Option 1 or 2 above)

If all six are checked, **you're ready**. See you in Session 1! 